

Sponsors on "Hill"

Civil Rights Congress Called Red Front in Report to House

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The House Un-American Activities Committee charged last night that the Civil Rights Congress is a "Communist front organization" whose sponsors include six present and former members of Congress.

The committee released a report on activities of the Civil Rights Congress, which was organized April 27 and 28, 1946, in Detroit by a merger of the International Labor Defense and National Federation of Constitutional Liberties. In its opening statement, the report said:

"Having adopted a line of militant skullduggery against the United States with the close of World War II, the Communist

Party has set up the Civil Rights Congress for the purpose of protecting those of its members who run afoul of the law."

The report made no attempt to say whether sponsors and supporters of the organization are Communist sympathizers or whether their interest was obtained by misrepresentation of the organization's purposes.

Members and former members of Congress listed as sponsors of the Civil Rights Congress are Senator Glenn H. Taylor (D., Idaho), former Representative Hugh Delacy (D., Wash.), former

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Representative Ellis E. Patterson (D., Calif.), Representative Adam Clayton Powell, jr. (D., N. Y.), former Representative William A. Rowan (D., Ill.), and former Representative Charles R. Savage (D., Wash.).

The report also listed Representative Vito Marcantonio, American Labor Party, New York, a former president of the International Labor Defense, as serving on various "initiating" committees of the Civil Rights Congress.

Among those who served with Marcantonio in this capacity, the report said, were Powell and his pianist wife, Hazel Scott; Actor Edward G. Robinson, Singer Paul Robeson, Bishop Edward L. Parsons of San Francisco and Writer Donald Ogden Stewart.

Among other sponsors of the Civil Rights Congress were Utah State Supreme Court Justice James H. Wolfe, Illinois State Representative Donald C. Teigland, Kentucky State Representative Charles W. Anderson, Susan B. Anthony 2d, Cleveland Councilman Charles N. Carr, President Rufus E. Clement of Atlanta University, Ring W. Lardner, jr., CIO General Counsel Lee Pressman, Prof. A. M. Schlesinger of Harvard University, Prof. F. O. Matthieson of Harvard University, and Prof. Dirk J. Struik of Massachusetts Institute of Technology.

Hammett a Contributor

Writer Dashiell Hammett was listed as one of its heaviest contributors.

The report said that many sponsors of the Civil Rights Congress were the same as those who sponsored the International Labor De-

fense and National Federation for Constitutional Liberties.

These latter organizations "had been so badly discredited by repeated exposure as to injure their usefulness in the newly envisaged campaign of Communist lawlessness," the report said.

It quoted former Attorney General Francis E. Biddle as describing the ILD as "the legal arm of the Communist Party," and the NFCL as having a program which "parallels closely the Communist Party line . . ."

In its conclusion, the committee reported that from the facts obtained, "it should be clear that the Civil Rights Congress is an organization dedicated, not to the broader issues of civil liberties, but specifically to the defense of individual Communists and the Communist Party."

Either Members or Loyal

"The organization is controlled by individuals who are either members of the Communist Party or openly loyal to it, and that in carrying out its defense aims, the organization has at the same time engaged in a campaign of vilification against the American Government," the report said.

The committee charged that the Civil Rights Congress had an "enormous financial income" obtained in part from Communist sympathizers and in part by "a spurious appeal in behalf of civil liberty."

Of the key individuals guiding the policies of the CRC, the committee said, "12 are outright leading members of the Communist Party, 25 have aided one or more leading Communists on occasion and 14 have signed statements in support or defense of the Communist Party."

Some Deny Connections

[Some of those mentioned denied connections with the Civil Rights Congress, the Associated Press reported.

[In Los Angeles, Patterson declared in his opinion the House Committee on Un-American Activities "is really un-American."

[In Shelton, Savage said when advised he had been named as among the congress founders, "that's the first I ever heard of it. I certainly was not at the Detroit meeting."

[Savage then expressed his opinion of the committee, saying "the members don't know what democracy means. The committee is out to perpetuate hate. It is out to destroy democracy in America. It is headed by narrow-minded men who never saw anything wrong with Fascists, such as Gerald L. K. Smith."

Proud to Be In It

[In Seattle, De Lacy commented: "The report is another in a long series of acts by the Rankin-Thomas committee intended to intimidate the expression of free opinion in this country. Calling prejudiced witnesses, having star chamber proceedings and citing anti-Fascists for contempt while the Coughlinites and the Gerald L. K. Smith followers go free. This is evidence of a real need for an American Civil Rights Congress. I am proud to have been in at the founding of this organization and I shall stay with it until the Rankins and Thomases are retired from public life."

[In Hollywood, Actor Edward G. Robinson said he didn't recall whether he had agreed to be one of the "initiating committee" of the Civil Rights Congress but "if I have lent my name I am sure it was in behalf of the best American ideals—I don't believe in communism and I never lend my name to any organization that smacks of communism."

[Robinson said Representative Patterson and Clark Foreman, mentioned by the House Commit-

tee as among backers of the congress, "are for my money Americans and not Communists."

["If the congress is fighting for civil rights, then it's important because civil rights are more important than ever in these hectic days," Robinson added.

[Professor Schlesinger said in Boston: "I withdrew my name from that organization before its first meeting in Detroit. I gave no reason and do not care to now."

[Former Representative Rowan remarked: "I don't remember the organization. I don't recall ever having authorized the use of my name."

[Illinois State Representative Tiegland said he didn't know he was an "official member" or sponsor of the Congress or that it was a Communist organization.

[He said his name might have been used when the Congress was organized, but that his chief connection with it was as chairman of

the Quad-City Industrial Union Council. He said the council cooperated with the Congress in defending civil rights of various persons, particularly Southern Negroes.

[Dr. Foreman said at Highlands, N. C., that the committee—he described it as the "Republican dominated Un-American Committee"—calls everyone who attacks it a Communist, adding:

["The grave abuses of power by the Un-American Committee should warn all of us of the totalitarianism which will come if we do not fight effectively now to save the American system."—Editor's note.]